

« I've never thought of myself as 'just' a para athlete. I want to inspire everyone »

PRAVEEN KUMAR

Winning gold in Men's high jump T64 at the Paris Paralympics changed my life. I cleared 2.08m, a personal best, and stood on top of the podium with the Indian flag. I'd won medals before, including a silver at the Tokyo Paralympics and gold at the Asian Para Games, but Paris felt different. It gave me a new sense of freedom. I don't worry about money the way I used to. If I want to shop, I shop. When Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium closed for World Championships renovations and I lost access to its gym, I bought my own weight set and installed it in the basement of my Delhi home. I've removed every excuse for not doing well.

Now, as the Para Athletics World Championships in New Delhi

approach, my focus is sharper than ever. This is the one medal missing from my collection. I've been unlucky with injuries — twice, including at both the Tokyo and Paris Paralympics, I hurt my take-off foot. But I'm trying to stay healthy this time. This Championship is not only important for me but also for para sports in India.

More than 100 countries will be



On the street, people might see only a 'disabled' person. But in the gym or on the field, I show them something they never imagined. That moment, when their perception changes, is what I enjoy most.

